

and not a strategic merger, is conveniently the only wife in Akbar's harem. She is the reason he turns to vegetarianism, parts ways with his influential foster mother Maham Naga and even abolishes the pilgrimage tax. She is also the force behind his desire to get closer to his subjects, and it is her words he echoes—"aap fateh karna jaante hain, par raj karna nahin" (you know how to conquer but not rule)—when he first goes to Agra Bazaar to see how his people lived. Jodha Bai is also shown to have a tendency of breaking into a Krishna bhajan whenever the Diwan-e-Aam is in session—that is when she is not stealing *Kama Sutra*-worthy glances at Akbar's glistening pecs or engaged in a swordfight-cum-mating dance across Amer Fort's zenana.

What Gowariker and Ali have cleverly done is to weave fiction around

"I was told not to get involved in history. But no one objected to *Mughal-e-Azam*, so why this?"

ASHUTOSH GOWARIKER, DIRECTOR

actual characters, in what Moosvi dismissively calls a "publicity stunt". Yes, Abul Fazl's *Akbar Nama* tells us that Akbar was offered the daughter—inconveniently never named—of Raja Bhara Mal of Amer in 1562. Historian Satish Chandra tells us that such alliances were part of Akbar's grand design of empire building and often the Rajputs' way of protecting themselves. So Bhara Mal is shown to have a dispute with his nephew Suja Mal, who then seeks the help of Akbar's rebel nobleman Mirza Sharf-ud-din Hussain. What the movie doesn't show is the importance of Bhara Mal's son Bhagwant

Das, a loyal Rajput who was in attendance on Akbar most of the time, built the Jama Masjid in Agra, and on more than one occasion guarded the imperial camp. Here though he is shown as a cipher who opens his mouth only once during the movie and that too to utter the dying Suja Mal's name. Maham Naga (played with campy venality by Ila Arun) is also given undue importance, given that Akbar had three other foster mothers. And rather than try to turn Akbar against Jodha Bai after he kills her son Adam Khan, Maham Naga actually retreated into private mourning and died quietly after 40 days.

Akbar was a visionary and strove for a synthesis between his Islamic and Central-Asian heritage as well as the Hindu culture and ethos of the lands he was conquering during his reign from 1556 to 1605. But Gowariker, in full-on Sanjay Leela Bhansali mode, has shown Akbar as being motivated solely by personal love in learning to treat his subjects—Hindu or Muslim—like his own. Moosvi says nothing could be further from the truth. "Akbar cut his hair when he was coronated in 1556 saying he wanted to be like his subjects. His first recorded *jagir* was also given to a Hindu dyer, Ustad Ramdas Rangrez, who remained in contact with the emperor till his death," says Moosvi. Nor was Jodha Bai Akbar's only Hindu wife—even Abdul Qadir Badauni, who unlike court historian Abul Fazl, was critical of Akbar in his *Muntakhabu't Tawarikh*, taunts the emperor saying he had gone to the extent of allowing his Hindu wives to worship images inside the mahal. To give more importance to Jodha Bai is to deny that Akbar was the product of a particular society where religious co-existence was accepted—even as early as Mohammed Tughluq's rule (1324-1351), the presence of Hindu officials in the administration was encouraged. Raja Todar Mal, Akbar's trusted aide, was also borrowed from the previous Sher Shah Suri administration.

But though Gowariker and Ali have done a disservice to history, they may well have stoked popular culture. In

FICTION

Jodhaa Akbar is lavish in scale but skimpy on facts

HINDU WIFE NAMED JODHA

Jodha Bai, the daughter of Raja Bhara Mal of Amer, was married to Akbar.

HER INFLUENCE Akbar gave up eating meat, abolished the pilgrimage tax and even started mingling with his subjects because of her.

FOSTER POWER Akbar's foster mother Maham Naga was powerful and tried to conspire against Jodha after he killed her son Adam Khan.

SOLE SOUL Jodha Bai, or let's say Raja Bhara Mal's daughter, was Akbar's only Hindu wife.

STRAIGHT ARROW That Akbar, though a mere child, had the presence of mind to aim for Hemu's eye, which swung victory for him in the Battle of Panipat in 1556.

FACT

DON'T KNOW Bhara Mal did offer his daughter to Akbar but her name was not Jodha Bai.

NOT AT ALL These decisions were part of Akbar's evolution and a product of the society in which he was living.

NO WAY Maham Naga was one of his four foster mothers and while close to Akbar, did nothing but retreat into private mourning after her son was killed.

THERE WERE OTHERS Like the niece of Rai Kalyan Mal of Bikaner and Jaisalmer's Rawal Har Rai's daughter.

ACCIDENT OF FATE The arrow was a fluke, though it did render Hemu unconscious, and led to the re-establishment of the Mughal dynasty.